



Maritime &
Coastguard
Agency

Guidance

MGN 468 – Amendment 1 (M) - Voluntary Towage Endorsement Scheme

Updated 11 May 2023

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Notice to all UK Port and Harbour Authorities, Shipowners and Operators engaged in towage work, Contractors and others conducting risk assessments of towage operations.

This notice should be read in conjunction with MSN 1853 (M) (<https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/msn-1853-m-boatmasters-qualifications-crew-and-hours-of-work>).

Summary

This notice describes the arrangement for the MCA recognised Voluntary Towage Endorsement Scheme. It has been developed at the request of the UK towage and workboat industry to help ensure that masters engaged in towage operations have the necessary skills for such specialist operations.

The notice identifies competence standards and the specific knowledge, understanding and proficiency needed to safely operate in this area of the maritime industry.

The voluntary towage endorsement scheme may assist port and harbour authorities conducting risk assessments of towage operations and developing safe systems of work as required by the Port Marine Safety Code.

Key points:

1. The towage endorsement scheme is voluntary and there is no statutory obligation to hold a towage endorsement to work in the towage industry.
2. Voluntary towage endorsements are intended to be used in conjunction with an appropriate Certificate of Competency (CoC) and are not in themselves a substitute for such a certificate.
3. There are three towage endorsements:
 - a. General Towage
 - b. Ship Assist Towage
 - c. Sea Towage
4. The general towage endorsement will be accepted as meeting the competence standard required for the issue of a 'towing and pushing' endorsement under the Boatmasters' Regulations [SI 2006 No. 3223 - The Merchant Shipping (Inland Waterway and Limited Coastal Operations) (Boatmasters' Qualifications and Hours of Work) Regulations 2006].

1. Introduction

1.1 The MCA recognises that certificates it issues under the International Convention on Standards of Training, Certification and Watchkeeping 1978, as amended, (STCW) and those issued by the Royal Yachting Association (RYA) and others are generic to the industry and there is no requirement for a separate statutory towage endorsement.

1.2 However, after consulting with industry the need for a voluntary towage endorsement scheme was identified. Voluntary towage endorsements will:

a. assist owners and operators engaged in towage work, or harbour masters, contractors and others when risk assessing towage operations; and

b. enable individuals to demonstrate that they are suitably experienced and competent to carry out such work.

1.3 Unless they wish to enhance their knowledge in a specific area of towage, this notice is not relevant for holders of tug specific Certificates of Competency ^[footnote 1].

2. Description of the Endorsements

2.1 There are three voluntary towage endorsements:

a. General Towage Endorsement

Towing and pushing in categorised waters^[footnote 2] or in limited coastal areas ^[footnote 3] (competence standard contained in Annex 1).

b. Ship Assist Towage Endorsement

Assisting with the berthing and un-berthing of vessels (competence standard contained in Annex 2).

c. Sea Towage Endorsement

Towage of vessels or floating objects at sea (competence standard contained in Annex 3).

3. Qualifying Conditions

3.1 Persons applying for voluntary towage endorsement must complete the training record book and show proof of relevant experience of towage tasks.

a. General Towage

A person will require to have attained a minimum of 120 days service in vessels whilst engaged upon acts of general towage for the award of this endorsement.

b. Ship Assist Towage

After completion of the General Towage endorsement, a further 120 days service in vessels whilst engaged upon specific 'ship assist' operations.

c. Sea Towage

After completion of the General Towage endorsement, a further 180 days service in vessels engaged upon Sea Towage, undertaking a minimum of 12 separate sea towage operations.

4. Assessment and Endorsement

4.1 Assessment and endorsement will be carried out by MCA Recognised Bodies. Assessment for each endorsement will consist of an oral exam covering the underpinning knowledge and a practical assessment. Successful candidates will be awarded the appropriate endorsement by the Recognised Body.

4.2 Voluntary towage endorsement assessors will be appointed by the MCA Recognised Body.

4.3 Assessors are expected to have a minimum of five years relevant experience in towing operations and relevant assessment experience.

5. Recognised Bodies

5.1 The National Workboat Association (NWA) is recognised by the MCA to carry out assessments and certification for the voluntary towage endorsement scheme.

5.2 The NWA is required to maintain a list of current assessors and records of candidates assessed and voluntary towage endorsements issued. They may make a charge for undertaking the assessment and issuing the endorsement to cover their assessor's costs and administrative overheads.

5.3 Contact details are:

The Workboat Association
Studio 22, Bayles House,
44-46 High Street,
Hull
HU1 1PS

Tel: 07824376717 Email: admin@workboatassociation.org

5.4 Applications to become a Recognised Body by the MCA under the Voluntary Towage Endorsement Scheme should be made in writing to the MCA Chief Examiner and submitted to the address at the end of this notice.

6. Application for Assessment for the Issue of a Voluntary Towage Endorsement

6.1 Candidates wishing to obtain the voluntary towage endorsements described in this document should apply to a Recognised Body as detailed in paragraph 5 to be assessed for the issue of a voluntary towage endorsement.

6.2 Holders of Boatmasters' Licences (BML) who wish to engage in towage operations must obtain the BML Towing and Pushing Endorsement in accordance with the requirements of the BML regulations. If the holder of a BML obtains the voluntary General Towage Endorsement then this will be accepted as meeting the requirements for the BML Towing and Pushing Endorsement.

7. Training Record Books

7.1 Candidates must complete the appropriate sections of the approved Training Record Book (TRB) for the Voluntary Towage Endorsement Scheme prior to being examined for a voluntary towage endorsement. When the relevant sections are completed, the TRB provides comprehensive documentary evidence of an approved training program. The TRB can be found on the [Workboat Association website](http://www.workboatassociation.org/training/) (<http://www.workboatassociation.org/training/>).

More Information

Seafarer Services
Maritime and Coastguard Agency,
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Spring Place,
105 Commercial Road,
Southampton,
SO15 1EG.

Tel: +44 (0) 203 8172200 Email: deck@mcga.gov.uk

Website Address: www.gov.uk/government/organisations/maritime-and-coastguard-agency

General Enquiries: infoline@mcga.gov.uk

1. The Voluntary Towage Endorsement Scheme is not intended to replace the BTA sponsored training or tug training route currently being developed by the MCA and our tug industry partners leading to the issue of a tug specific Certificate of Competence under STCW.
2. Refer to [MSN 1837 \(M\) Amendment 2– Categorisation of Waters](https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/msn-1837-m-amendment-2-categorisation-of-waters) (<https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/msn-1837-m-amendment-2-categorisation-of-waters>).
3. Limited coastal area, as defined in the Boatmasters' Regulations, means an area of the sea where the vessel is neither more than 15 miles (exclusive of waters of category A, B, C or D) from its point of departure nor more than 3 miles from land.



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